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What is relationality? Indigenous knowledges, practices and responsibilities with kin

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Abstract

This paper delves into the concept of relationality and pairs academic literature with stories and lessons from Country. Bringing together majority Indigenous scholarship on relationality, the paper describes three main ideas: (1) How does a relational reality operate? (2) Relationality as a living practice and, (3) Relationality as responsibilities with kin. Many examples are provided to explain relationality in practical and concrete ways. As a trawlwulwuy woman, I weave the stories and lessons from Country throughout the paper, with a particular focus on research. I consider an inverse of relationality, extractivism, and identify how many dominant research practices are deeply extractive. The paper concludes with prompts for the reader on how research can be a more relational process. Overall, the paper demonstrates a relational ethos in (and out of) practice.

Keywords

Aboriginal, extractivism, Indigenous, Indigenous research methodologies, literature review, relationality

Introductions

Relationality is learnt from stories, watching our Old People yarn or sitting with Country – relationality is seldom learnt from academic journal articles. Country inhabits all relationality and is used widely across Australia to describe how all land is Aboriginal land, Aboriginal Country; Country is agentic and encompasses everything from ants, memories, humans, fire, tides and research. Country sits at the heart of coming to know and understand relationality as it is the web that connects humans to a system of Lore/Law and knowledge that can never be human-centric. Human geography is a misnomer in this sense, seemingly applying a human-centric perspective to notions of geography that, by definition, encompass the realms of land, place and Country. For

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human geography, placing relationality and Country as the starting point to research practice is vital, as what is at stake is a present and future out of balance, of increasing wildfires, floods and the suffering of kin; a human-centric future.

Relationality belongs with and is learnt from Country, however, as Indigenous knowledges and research methodologies gain recognition in academia, there is an increasing need for Indigenous scholars to articulate relational practices in print form, echoing de Leeuw and Hunt's call to, 'make Indigenous peoples lived realities more visible on their own terms' and emphasise that relationality is not a new metaphor to be reaped for academic gain, but a practice bound with responsibilities with kin and Country.[1] Cree scholar Shawn Wilson emphasises that an 'Indigenist reality is relationships . . . relationships are reality, and reality is relationships. As Indigenous people, we 'are' our relationships with other people'.[2] So, what does it mean to *be* relational, and how do we *practice* this ethos with Country, with each other and our research? This paper first asks how a relational reality operates, before outlining relationality as practice and then relationality as responsibilities with kin. The paper then turns to research to consider how relationality can be practiced when research itself tends to be extractive. Finally, the stories lead us to lessons in relationality and ask, what does this mean for you as a researcher?

In an attempt to discuss the literature in a relational way, the majority Indigenous scholarship is woven with many examples of relationality and my own stories of a relational ethos in (and out of) practice. Sarah Hunt emphasises that, 'stories and storytelling are widely acknowledged as culturally nuanced ways of knowing, produced within networks of relational meaning-making'.[3] Discussing the literature with storied examples from Country is also a way to perform relationality as reciprocity. Tuck and McKenzie describe reciprocity as an 'epistemic touchstone of Indigenous methodologies' that 'is concerned with maintaining balance not just between humans, but with energies that connect and thread through all entities in the universe. This not a mystical statement, but one that is grounded in Indigenous metaphysics'.[4] As a trawlwulwuy[5] woman, I begin this story with Country and wonder, if this paper is about relationality, will Country write this paper?

Will country write this paper?

I wanted to write this paper while sitting with my ancestral Country, tebrakunna, in northeast Tasmania, in the country now known as Australia. After all, this is a paper about relationality, with a focus on relationships with Country. I travelled up to tebrakunna country to write this paper. I pictured myself sitting under a casuarina tree with toes in the bright white sand, feeling the warmth of granite boulders beneath me as a paper just gushed forth onto the page. I think I was expecting Country to write this paper for me, for you. That didn't happen. I got there, with a huge purple storm front on my tail as we drove the dirt roads up north. Stepping out of the car, a swarm of flies clung to me, batting at my eyes and ears, clinging on despite the great winds. The wind in tebrakunna country is big – Bass Strait, Southern Ocean big (Figure 1). I left the laptop and notebook in the car.

I'm now writing this paper in the airplane, as I literally fly over the top of tebrakunna country. I can see the massive sand dunes and lagoons, the sea water looking calm as it travels past the cape. We fly straight over Country, over the Bass Strait that separates Tasmania from mainland Australia.

I went to tebrakunna with an expectation that a paper would materialise from my connection with my ancestral country, that it/she/he/they (Country) would write a paper on relationality. I expected my relationship with Country to be the source of my academic inspiration. I realise I went to Country with an extractive mentality. Extractivism sits at the core of colonialism; the extraction of knowledge, labour, specimens, resources, relationships and research.[6] Extractivism can seep into research practices, often in the quest to produce 'original' research.[7]



Figure 1. Author on tebrakunna country with wind, flies and storm front. Photo by Lauren Tynan, 2019.

Country taught me a lesson about relationality; you cannot demand a relationship, nor give it a deadline. This does not diminish the creative inspiration inherent in Country, nor its capacity as an original storyteller and teacher (whose pedagogical tools may be wind, flies and storms). But it reframes the lessons we expect to learn from Country. As teacher, Country taught me that despite the deadlines and fieldwork timeframes in research, to work with a relational ethos means responding and *listening* to Country, and her timeframes; a lesson that can be applied to other contexts and Peoples too.

Relationality is not easy, especially when living in a settler-colony. It means sometimes we are out of practice or taught by the university to research in non-relational and extractive ways, using strict time frames, restrictive academic writing styles, hierarchical notions of expertise and colonial discourses of 'discovery', 'finding the gap' and 'collecting data'.[8] Relationality is about connection, to Peoples and Country, but connection to Country is not always rosy either. Indigenous identity is defined by relationships, primarily with Country,[9] which is often portrayed with mystique and romanticism.[10] However, connection to Country also means connecting to unwanted messages, like feeling the grief of Country when she is burning or hurting.[11] Relationality with Country and relationality as an ethos means being prepared to listen to messages we may not want or expect to hear. Relationality, being *in good relation*[12] is being willing to cop a mouthful of flies and sand in eyes. It means despite the best intentions to work *with* Country to write a paper on relationality, that Country might work against you, and thus, teach you an even bigger lesson about being a good relative.

How does a relational reality operate?

Dudgeon and Bray explain that 'Indigenous relationality is recognized as the life force, and that which supports and nourishes life'.[13] Relationality is a central concept within Indigenous worlds, Alfred and Corntassel suggest that relationships 'are the spiritual and cultural foundations of

Indigenous peoples'.[14] As a foundation, relationality is how the world is known and how we, as Peoples, Country, entities, stories and more-than-human kin know ourselves and our responsibilities to one another. Wilson notes that 'relationships do not merely shape reality, they *are* reality'.[15] How does a relational reality operate? What does it mean to understand the world as relational? As an example, let's play a word game.

Question:	How are a river and a mountain similar?
Alex's answer:	They are both part of nature.

In this word game, Alex's answer is the most common response, it will score them top points. Alex looks for likeness between the entities by identifying how they are *the same.* To do this, Alex categorises the two entities into a broader classification, nature. Let's ask Lexi the same question.

Question:	How are a river and a mountain similar?
Lexi's answer:	The river flows down from the mountain.

Lexi's answer is an uncommon response, the game has not included this answer in its pre-set list of responses, so Lexi scores zero. Lexi looks for likeness between the two entities by identifying a *relationship* they hold to one another. Rather than using a classificatory practice, Lexi demonstrates a relational reality in which the river and mountain are alike due to their relationality, their kinship.

Goldberg notes that a relational account tends to ripple out and 'stress the (re-)production of relational ties and their mutually effecting and reinforcing impacts', whereas a comparativist account can be more broad stroke as it draws on impressions rather than detail, emphasising difference and separate-ness.[16] Alex's answer compares the two entities and classifies them together in a broad stroke category, nature. Classificatory practices are a common feature of Western knowledge systems, particularly arising during the Enlightenment period of Western Europe from the 1700s onward.[17] During this period, a focus on the Industrial Revolution and the natural sciences gave rise to specific ways of thinking such as rationality and scientific taxonomy which tended to conceive of the world in classifications, hierarchies and binaries.[18] The word game itself is premised on these notions, with a pre-set list of responses ranked according to perceived accuracy and scored accordingly. Although I have framed this as a playful word game, the mechanics of the game reflect the 'hidden' values and assumptions of testing that are implicit across many Western education practices. These hidden values prompt questions that Michelle Bishop proposes, 'what definition of knowledge is this based on? . . . Testing as a concept and practice is not objective, it comes from an epistemology that tries to classify, compare, define people (Western science)'.[19] Relationality is not about comparison; it is about unity and kinship.

A relational reality creates relationships between ideas or entities, it is an affective force that compels us to not just *understand* the world as relational, but *feel* the world as kin.[20] I can tell you that the world is relational and you may believe me, but beyond understanding the concept of relationality, to *feel* the world as kin is to enact a relational ethos and the responsibilities and accountabilities that accompany it.[20] For example, a relational reality underpins the way many Aboriginal people in Australia greet one another. Rather than asking, 'What's your name? What sort of work do you do?', Aboriginal people often ask, 'Who are you? Where are you from?' The former question relies on classificatory practices that value individuality and the labour market, whilst the latter creates a relational network where people can establish kinship relationships; strengthening sameness across difference. The question 'Who are you?' is actually asking, 'who are you related to? How are you related to me?', which decentres the individual and gives primacy to a collective and relational reality between Peoples. The second question 'Where are you from?' decentres the human and looks for relational ties based on Country (ancestral or lived) and more-than-human

LAKOTA DO THE SAME

kin. Introductions are foundational to many Aboriginal communities, especially in the southeast of Australia. Introductions serve to *find* connections within a relational reality where everyone and everything is related.

Relationality as practice

Relationality is premised on a truth that 'all things exist in relatedness' and whilst this is a naturally occurring principle of many Indigenous worldviews, it is a principle that is sustained and strengthened through practice.[21] Karen Martin goes on to define relatedness itself as 'sets of conditions, processes and practices' that occur between entities, including through research practices.[22] When all things exist in relatedness, it is inconceivable that an entity, idea or person could exist *outside* of this network, or be considered as 'Other' to this system of relationality. This section will look at examples of relationality as practice through the lessons from 'otherness', Sky, Fire and Caring as Country.

Otherness

To conceive of something or someone as 'Other' is to sever an inherent relationship between things and reify certain Peoples or ideas as more important.[23] To consider Indigenous Peoples as 'less than human' represents a non-relational and hierarchical practice that defined/defines colonial relations in settler colonies, positioning the 'Other' as outside this matrix of relatedness.[24] In the trawlwulwuy context of Tasmania, 'otherness' was truly severed from a relational core by proclaiming Tasmanian Aboriginal Peoples to be physically non-existent, as extinct.[25] trawlwulwuy countrywoman Emma Lee, writing as tebrakunna country and Lee, considers how we as trawlwulwuy peoples can undertake a process of cultural resurgence to reclaim our 'web of relationships [that] are mediated through country, and encompass the things of lands, seas and night skies as well as ancestor and creator beings, and define how we connect with the world'.[26] tebrakunna country and Lee gesture to relationality as that which brings us *into existence* through practice and process; where trawlwulwuy existence is premised on the *practice* of our relational reality.

Sky

Country itself is known through relationality and our connections to Country become realised through relational practices. More formalised relational practices with Country are often referred to as ceremony and can be used to bridge the distance between two entities, such as Peoples and Country, and create a stronger relationality.[27] The concept of ceremony helps emphasise and perform the transformative potential *between* entities, rather than focus on entities as separate and individual beings. For example, when looking at the night sky, it is easy to focus on the stars, planets and materiality of the Milky Way; the individual entities of the sky. Another view of the night sky appreciates the silences and perceived empty spaces in between these objects.[28] This view reveals the dark shapes, and in the skies of eastern Australia, this view reveals an emu in the Milky Way whose shape grows and wanes with the seasons providing indicators for land-based emu nesting seasons. This connection becomes a practice as it occurs repeatedly over time, emphasising relational ways of Knowing, Being and Doing between entities.[29] As a relational practice, sky-camp (the sky) and earth-camp (the land), come together through ceremony to bridge the distance between these two entities and create stronger relationality. This is how connection is realised through relational practices, where nothing is black or empty space, and the practice occurs in the relationship *between* entities.

During the 2019/2020 megafires that roared across southeastern Australia, the sky took on a new and disturbing relationality between different entities. I remember the red darkness during the day, the sky heaving with thick and toxic smoke, an early introduction to masks before the COVID-19 pandemic. What was that smoke that seeped through the cracks in our doors and trickled into our lungs? Not a separate entity, the smoke was the ashes of our kin, the loss of over 1 billion animals and 7 million hectares of Country: sacred trees, medicines, ancient grasses and soils. In this new relationality of Sky, animal kin floated in the air and into our bodies, forming sameness across difference, unity across disaster. This same ashy-smoke formed new relationalities, pyrocumulus clouds above the raging fires, creating their own weather system, including lightening strikes that sparked new fires hundreds of kilometres away from the fire front. These new relationalities are also borne of practice, a practice of colonial-mismanagement of Country that treats the land as a resource for extraction, Indigenous knowledges as 'Other', and fire as an entity to fight, rather than as kin to be nurtured. Relationality can manifest with disturbing lessons when entities create sameness across difference by forming relationships of destruction. This is why caretaking relationships in all contexts (land management, family and research) is important.

Fire

Another example of relationality as practice can be seen through cultural practices such as cool burning. During the winter months, I spend time burning Country in a way that is slow, healing and uses a whole of system approach to fire; in Australia we call this cultural burning as it differs from mainstream fire management practices.[30] In this practice, whilst myself as a trawlwulwuy woman and the fire I am putting on the ground are important entities in how I care as Country, it is the relationship *between* myself and the fire that articulates relatedness. Dudgeon and Bray highlight that 'understanding Indigenous 'relationality' requires attention to the *process* of connection',[31] which in the case of cultural burning is about connection between myself as a human, the fire on the ground and all entities present in this practice. As a relational practice, cultural burning enables Peoples (or birds, lightening and other entities) to bring their relationship with fire together so that the two (or multiple) entities are more unified as one.

Whilst cultural burning serves as a land management practice, its primary purpose is the health and wellbeing of Mother (Country) and all kin who rely on her. This differs from the goal of protecting assets and human life that is generally prioritised in hazard reduction burning and other Western land management practices, often at a great cost to non-human life.[32] Cultural burning is not about management, which implies a hierarchy of beings in which humans are seen to have sole authority over the land.[33] Cultural burning is about relatedness in which human beings have responsibility to care for kin, to care for or *as* Country.[34] It is for this reason that community members and scholars such as Bawaka Country including Suchet-Pearson et al., have reframed the notion of 'Caring for Country' to become 'Caring *as* Country'.[35]

Caring-as-country

FOR LAKOTA WE SAY MAKOCE

Country is a term used by many Aboriginal groups in Australia to delineate understandings from the English word 'land'. Mary Graham notes that understanding land as just land implies an extractive logic, where land exists for the primary benefit of humans to extract resources for monetary gain or acquire land as property.[36] These logics have dominated settler relations with land in Australia since invasion.[37] However, understanding land as Country foregrounds a relational logic whereby Country is seen to exert its own agentic force or Lore/Law.[38] Practices of Caring for/as Country are therefore relational practices of care, rather than processes of extraction or ownership.[39]

As a relational concept, Caring *as* Country is also about co-becoming. Bawaka Country including Suchet-Pearson et al. note that 'human and more-than-human *beings* never *are* – not isolated, not static, not known – but only *become* as they constantly emerge together'.[40] Dynamic and generative, co-becoming explains how practices of Caring as Country are not uni-lateral – human burning the bush – but are relational practices that involve all entities – human, fire, bloodwood tree, ancestors, wind, story, song. If 'humans are part of Country and not separate from it', then our practices of care are not *for* Country, but are us *being* Country and Caring *as* Country.[41] Graham suggests this is created through 'the sacralization of obligation and the putting of this obligation into practice via ceremonies, social structures, organizing principles, patterning (identity imprinting), laws, repetition of narratives'.[42] Graham emphasises that relationality is a practice based on obligation or, responsibilities.

Relationality as responsibilities with kin

> Can you imagine a world where nature is understood as full of relatives not resources, where inalienable rights are balanced with inalienable responsibilities and where wealth itself is measured not by resource ownership and control, but by the number of good relationships we maintain in the complex and diverse life-systems of this blue green planet? I can.[43]

I can too, because my ancestors have passed to me a living memory of this world. Watts notes that, through an Indigenous lens, 'habitats and ecosystems are better understood as societies',[44] as agentic and complex realms with governance and education systems, and families. Relationality underpins Daniel Wildcat's vision above, because it describes a world that is comprised of relations or kin, where connections between entities are more important than the entities themselves. As societies and families, relationships are configured around responsibilities. Larsen and Johnson speak of these responsibilities as a form of reciprocal guardianship which,

> provides a balance between the members of this interrelated web where one member, such as humans, are not allowed to dominate, and where everyone, humans in particular have lessons to learn about their responsibility to listen and observe their relatives' interaction, in becoming ethical members of this family.[45]

Mary Graham describes this as a relationalist ethos where 'the two most important kinds of relationship in life are, firstly, those between land and people and, secondly, those amongst people themselves, the second being always contingent upon the first'. The relationship between land and humans is held together by an intricate web of relatedness that envelopes all entities.

A relationalist ethos considers truths to be multiple and the land as the source of all meaning. Graham posits that Aboriginal Peoples' relationalist ethos ensures a balance in social relations or, what she describes as a 'custodial ethic', which 'is so essential not only to Aboriginal society but to any society that intends to continue for millennia and wants to regard itself as mature'.[46] Through this philosophy of custodianship, land is known as a spiritual entity and human societies are dependent upon the land, incentivising good relations and care-taking responsibilities. In her own words, Graham notes,

> the intrinsic part of this understanding is expressed as the sacralising of the relationship between Land and human beings which, in turn, led to the fundamental principle of custodianship or a permanent, standing obligation to look after Land, society and social relations – the Law.[47]

Custodianship or a relationalist ethos describes how relationality is balanced by responsibility. Remembering Karen Martin's explanation that relationality is a practice, Graham's notion of

relationality as responsibility gives purpose to this practice, which in the context of Aboriginal society, Graham describes as the Law. Relationality with land is understood by many Indigenous Peoples as an ethic of responsibility, in contrast to an ethic of rights-based entitlement that is present in many Western logics.[48] Leanne Simpson notes that responsibility is missing from many contemporary practices.[49] Simpson explains the conundrum where Indigenous knowledges, technologies and relational philosophies are finally being understood by settler-society as beneficial to social and environmental wellbeing, but the ways these knowledges are taken up is through deeply extractive processes. Simpson notes,

> the extractivist mindset isn't about having a conversation and having a dialogue and bringing in indigenous [sic] knowledge on the terms of indigenous [sic] peoples . . . Because I think when people extract things, they're taking and they're running and they're using it for just their own good . . . The alternative is deep reciprocity. It's respect, it's relationship, it's responsibility, and it's local.[50]

As an ethic of responsibility, relationality is something that is practiced. Often, the processes of engaging with Indigenous Peoples and knowledges does not mimic the relational ethos through which knowledge and relationships are offered. Relationality is often discarded in the quest for fragments of Indigenous knowledge to be extracted, assimilated and consumed by the settler-colony. Research is no exception to this rationale.[51]

If relationality is also about responsibilities, then the tension between relationality and research is that research must not jeopardise responsibilities with kin; family, Country, and the futurities of those relationships. As Wilson emphasises, 'what is more important and meaningful is fulfilling a role and obligations in the research relationship – that is, being accountable to your relations'.[52] I listen back to my recorded yarns while traveling through tebrakunna country, reflecting on my goal of the trip – to write a paper on relationality and relationships with Country. In these yarns, I am deeply troubled. Troubled by the pressure I had inadvertently put on my relationship with Country to produce an academic output and be a source of academic inspiration. By labelling the trip 'fieldwork', I had commodified my relationship with Country and mimicked an extractive mentality that is all too present is research. Research should be about responsibility to Country and community first.

Trained out of relationality: extractivism

Research has a long history tied to colonialism and the extraction or theft of knowledges.[53] As Tuck and Yang explain,

> most research rhetoric waxes the poetics of empire: to discover, to chart new terrain, to seek new frontiers, to explore, and so on. The academy's unrelenting need to produce 'original research' is what makes the inquiry an invading structure, not an event.[54]

The extractive model of research practice mirrors extractive relationships with land.[55] This is not a relational ethos, it is not reciprocal nor based on respect for Country or the Peoples who sustain it. It is based on economic progress and the myth of limitless growth.[56] Graham notes that 'the land, and how we treat it, is what determines our human-ness', human societies are dependent upon the land, and this dependence has nothing to do with economic wealth.[57] Instead, Graham is referring to our very survival as Peoples. Graham describes this as a 'relationalist ethos', a way of living and being that is differentiated (but not in binary) from a 'survivalist mode'. A survivalist mode is characterised by Western logics that are focused on themselves and their own survival,

often enabled by extractivism. A relationalist ethos considers the land as the source of all meaning, echoing Aluli-Meyer's assertion that, 'one does not simply learn about land, we learn best *from* land'.[58]

As I write this paper, huge swathes of Country in the states of New South Wales and Victoria (Australia) are on fire or burnt to ashes; 7 million hectares of land destroyed.[59] As a human society we are dependent upon this land, but a lack of relational practice means this land is on fire, in a destructive way. Australian Government agencies have treated fire as a singular entity, without regard for the whole system fire interacts with and the thousands of relationships that depend on *good* fire.[60] Good fire is slow and healing, it belongs with the land and is a relational entity. Relationships with other kin (such as birds, winds and water) *enable* good fire to occur. Without these relationships, fire is encouraged to burn without limit, threatening all species, becoming wildfire. As relationality is foundational to the health and wellbeing of all entities, removing those relationships is extractive. As Leanne Simpson explains,

> the act of extraction removes all of the relationships that give whatever is being extracted meaning . . . extracting is stealing – it is taking without consent, without thought, care or even knowledge of the impacts that extraction has on the other living things in that environment. That's always been a part of colonialism and conquest.[61]

Extraction is also tied to efficiency or perceived productivity. Mainstream fire practices in Australia are premised on efficiency, these are often called hazard reduction burns and prioritise asset protection rather than the wellbeing of kin and Country.[62] In the research context, extraction can be subtle, yet is also bound to productivity; this is a value that is becoming more embedded in the expectations of academic work.[63] Corntassel reflects on these values in formal academic training, noting,

> I always believed that the amount it took to earn my PhD (eight years) demanded an equal or greater amount of time to decolonize and unlearn some of the *yonega* (white settler) frameworks and ways of thinking that became embedded in my professional and personal life.[64]

Even Indigenous research methodologies, which are premised on relationality,[65] are at risk of being squeezed into efficient and colonizing processes, resulting in what Foley refers to as 'the McDonaldisation of Indigenous methodology . . . an inexorably self-extending process of standardisation and over simplification', in service of the individual.[66] The 'McDonaldisation' approach may include the citation of Indigenous authors' words without reflection on or practice of what they are asking of researchers. It may include heavy inclusion of Indigenous scholarship and concepts in the methodologies section, without *practicing* those methodologies in the data collection, research design or ethical engagement with research participants. The 'McDonaldisation' approach occurs due to the value placed on written academic outputs and the ease in which print text can *tell* you what's been done, without having to *show* you. Indigenous scholarship, such as relational methodologies, are vulnerable to extraction. Tuck likens extractive academic practices to, 'panning for gold, sorting through work . . . sorting it by what is useful and what is discardable . . . for particular content to be removed for future use', neglecting the relationship between things.[67] Extraction, efficiency and productivity run deep through the veins of research in neoliberal universities,[68] where economic imperatives dictate the quality of education and research. With a focus on high student numbers, low staff costs (often achieved through casualisation), and research impact being measured through an increasingly privatised system of publication, the neoliberal university demands a type of knowledge production that has economic value. Such values can be nimble in their subterfuge of relationality.

I delayed beginning this paper on relationality until I knew I would visit my ancestral Country. This decision was bolstered by two ideas, (1) being on my ancestral Country would result in deeper thinking on relationality, (2) I would be wasting time trying to write this paper in my office when Country probably had messages for me to convey about relationality. Whilst I was trying to be as responsive and reflective as possible, there's no denying that this approach was also prompted by efficiency: the paper will just materialise when on Country. This paper did not magically appear on Country, but the messages Country conveyed to me about relationality did come, although they were in the form of a warning. In many Aboriginal communities, this is often called a growling, when a senior person *growls* you for not following protocol (i.e. doing something irresponsible). It felt like Country growled me for being extractive. This became my lesson on relationality. Whilst extractivism reigns supreme in the university, relationality runs even deeper through the veins of Country – it just might sound or look different to what we expect.

What does this mean for you as a researcher?

Relationality is multiple truths. As Mary Graham asserts, relationality teaches us that truths are multiple and are taught by the land. This can be extended to understand that knowledges and expertise are plural too. Through a relational ethos, the researcher is not the expert, in fact, the researcher *relies* on the knowledge, stories and intellectual property of participants (humans and more-than-humans) to be seen as an expert. In the case of research with Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander communities, the researcher's 'original' contribution is often contingent on being shared Indigenous Cultural and Intellectual Property (ICIP). Kearney and Janke define ICIP as 'Indigenous People's rights to their heritage and culture. Heritage includes all aspects of cultural practices, traditional knowledge, and resources and knowledge systems developed by Indigenous people as part of their Indigenous identity'.[69] In the quest for 'original' research and to fulfil academic requirements to publish, too often, as Tuck and Yang point out, 'social science hunts for new objects of study, and its favored reaping grounds are Native, urban, poor, and Othered communities'.[70] To contend with the extractive values of research culture, a relational ethos is therefore about benefit sharing, co-authorship, and who has *author*-ity[71] to share stories.

Relationality is also about agency. Concerned about the extraction of Indigenous knowledges and stories, Watts notes that 'non-Indigenous peoples also keep control over what agency is and how it is dispersed in the hands of humans'.[72] However, as Bawaka Country including Suchet-Pearson et al. note, relationality teaches us that 'agency is not just the remit of humans'.[73] For example, Country exerted its agency by disrupting my expectations of the research process; flies, sand, wind, storm and rain all gathered around me as a strong reminder of the presences and power of Country. The same can be said of fire. In my own research on cultural burning, I respect the agency of fire as a co-researcher who directs the scope and outcomes of the research project; what I refer to as a fire-led methodology. As a methodology, fire is seen to lead the research in unexpected, yet relational and generative ways. As I am learning, relationality shows that 'the research methodology is iterative and led by phenomena often beyond my control'.[74]

Relationality is kinship. A relational approach does not attempt to segment and classify the world but create stronger relationality (or ceremony) between entities. As Wilson succinctly describes, a relational methodology is 'simply the building of more relations'.[75] Through kinship, Martin knows that 'all things exist in relatedness',[76] and for Wilson, 'research by and for Indigenous peoples is a ceremony that brings relationships together'.[77]

Relationality is responsibility, with kin and Country first and foremost. Mary Graham's[78] scholarship is a reminder that, as humans, we are dependent upon the land. This dependency should incentivise us to care-take the land and be a good relative. Graham's work also describes this as a custodial

ethic of responsibility, expanding the current (neoliberal and human centric) concept of research ethics to account for care and our more-than-human kin. Understanding relationality as a responsibility, gives purpose to relational research practices. It is our responsibility to research in relational ways.

Relationality is practice. Sometimes, it takes practice to live and research relationally. My own research process has been defined by stories of a relational ethos in (and out of) practice, as I attempt to push against dominant expectations of research. It takes practice to be attentive to mainstream research processes that are often extractive, especially as a doctoral student encouraged to attend research methods seminars. However, relationality is not an end goal, nor a stand-alone practice, it leads on from and toward multiple practices that can also enrich research. As Victor Steffensen emphasises, 'one cultural practice needs to relate and inspire another practice',[79] continuing to build a stronger relationality *between* entities, focusing on the relationships, rather than the objects.

Knowledges, practices and responsibilities with kin

I can almost hear the car bump along the muddy roads, see the chunky backs of wallabies as they bound away and feel the wind whip sand at my ankles, the stories of tebrakunna country. All these moments are lessons on relationality and our expectations of Country, especially in academic disciplines such as human geography. For human geography, relationality actually decentres the human and focuses on the relationships *between* entities, the *processes* of connection and the responsibility to treat Country (kin and research) with respect. I am reminded of the megafires, a sign of colonial mismanagement of Country that attempts to segment and 'manage' the land, and wonder how long it will take for the Enlightenment thinking of the 1700s to be really disrupted in academic scholarship and practice. Will understanding relational research practices as a *responsibility* (to Country, kin and our collective futures) be enough to rethink neoliberal logics that incentivise responsibility to a financial economy?

Mary Graham reminds me that 'the two most important kinds of relationship in life are, firstly, those between land and people and, secondly, those amongst people themselves, the second being always contingent upon the first'.[80] While I continue my research on relationships with Country, I am learning that my *living* (dreaming, spirit, embodied) relationship with Country must not be leveraged or extracted for academic gain. My relationship with Country cannot be separated from my academic work, but it also must not be compromised by academic work; this takes practice. Rather, relationality describes a reality in which all entities are related, and it is our responsibilities to kin and Country that define our relational practices of care.

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